

Step One

Overcoming your financial baggage

It's not really fair that the first step in the process is probably one of the hardest, but coming to terms with, and letting go of, your money mistakes is like laying the foundations of a house. It's not necessarily visible in the finished product, but skip it and your house will fall down – either immediately, or at some point in the future when you're least expecting it. In order for your new habits to properly take hold, you need to learn to understand your old ones, and identify anything that might sabotage your attempts to change them. There are many things that keep us locked in cycles of unwanted behaviour, and there's no evidence to suggest that it's possible to cut corners just because we're talking about something that can be measured in notes and coins.

Making peace with your mistakes is not only about habit change but self-forgiveness. Self-flagellation and shame are often defining factors in keeping us stuck in the same place, or even the same downward spiral. When we continue to define ourselves by mistakes that we have made in the past, we are telling ourselves that they could recur at any moment – and then, more often than not, they do. I've spoken to so many